

INDIA AND THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

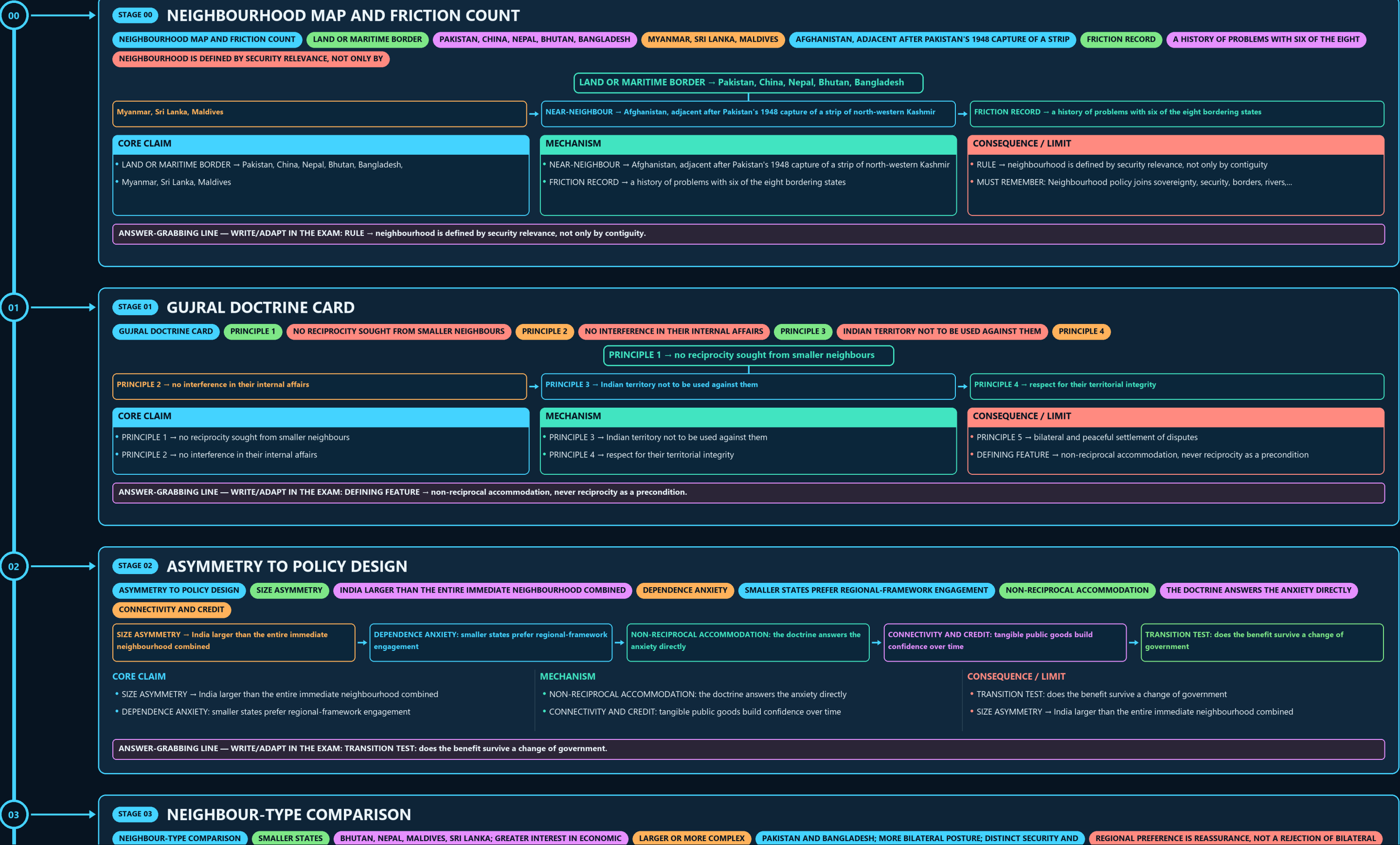
NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION → GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD → ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN → NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON → CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER → DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g6 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles



03

• SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

• DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

• NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly

• CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

• TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government

• SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government.

03

STAGE 03

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

SMALLER STATES

BHUTAN, NEPAL, MALDIVES, SRI LANKA; GREATER INTEREST IN ECONOMIC

LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX

PAKISTAN AND BANGLADESH; MORE BILATERAL POSTURE; DISTINCT SECURITY AND

REGIONAL PREFERENCE IS REASSURANCE, NOT A REJECTION OF BILATERAL

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka	regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security	QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
greater interest in economic integration	LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics	SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

CORE CLAIM

• SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

• greater interest in economic integration

MECHANISM

• regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security

• LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery

• SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery.

04

STAGE 04

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

1 NOVEMBER 2023

AKHAURA-AGARTALA CROSS-BORDER RAIL LINK INAUGURATED

BBIN MOTOR VEHICLES AGREEMENT SIGNED; BHUTAN NON-RATIFICATION CONSTRAINS IT

720 MW MANGDECHHU COMMISSIONED, THEN HANDED OVER TO BHUTAN

MAY 2023

KALADAN WATERWAY AND SITTWE PORT OPERATIONALISED; ROAD COMPONENT LAGGED

1 JUNE 2026

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated	2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan	1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it	MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged	RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

CORE CLAIM

• 1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated

• 2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it

MECHANISM

• 2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan

• MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• 1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion

• RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed.

05

STAGE 05

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

SRI LANKA

SEVEN MOUS, 5 APRIL 2025; BRIEF CURRENT TO JULY

JOINT VISION 7 OCTOBER 2024; FTA TERMS OF REFERENCE

INR 4,850 CRORE LINE OF CREDIT; BRIEF CURRENT TO

INR 100 BILLION FOR THE 13TH FIVE YEAR PLAN

2025; GELEPHU MINDFULNESS CITY SUPPORT 12 NOVEMBER 2025

VISION, TERMS OF REFERENCE, MEMORANDUM AND CREDIT ARE PRE-DELIVERY

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning	BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September	CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing...
MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025	2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025	
INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026	LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments	

CORE CLAIM

• SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning

• MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025

• INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026

MECHANISM

• BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September

• 2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025

• LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing.

06

STAGE 06

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

BY 3 MAY 2022

MORE THAN USD 3 BILLION RECORDED IN ASSISTANCE DURING

USD 1 BILLION

FACILITY FOR FOOD, MEDICINES AND ESSENTIALS

USD 500 MILLION

PETROLEUM CREDIT LINE; CLOSE TO 400,000 TONNES OF FUEL

ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

INDIA AND THE NEIGHBOURHOOD • TILE 2/4 • same master rows 2734-5968 of 11436 • continues below

- LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing.

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
BY 3 MAY 2022 → more than USD 3 billion recorded in assistance during 2022	USD 500 million → petroleum credit line; close to 400,000 tonnes of fuel delivered	USD 400 million → Reserve Bank of India currency swap; 25 districts covered
USD 1 billion → facility for food, medicines and essentials	ABOUT USD 1 billion → Asian Clearing Union payment deferment	LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained

CORE CLAIM

- BY 3 MAY 2022 → more than USD 3 billion recorded in assistance during 2022
- USD 1 billion → facility for food, medicines and essentials

MECHANISM

- USD 500 million → petroleum credit line; close to 400,000 tonnes of fuel delivered
- ABOUT USD 1 billion → Asian Clearing Union payment deferment

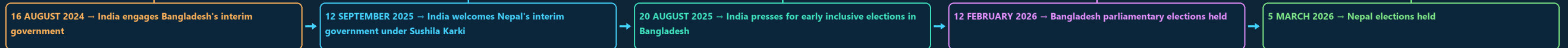
CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- USD 400 million → Reserve Bank of India currency swap; 25 districts covered
- LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained.

TRANSITION-TEST TIMELINE

12 FEBRUARY 2026



CORE CLAIM

- 16 AUGUST 2024 → India engages Bangladesh's interim government
- 12 SEPTEMBER 2025 → India welcomes Nepal's interim government under Sushila Karki

MECHANISM

- 20 AUGUST 2025 → India presses for early inclusive elections in Bangladesh
- 12 FEBRUARY 2026 → Bangladesh parliamentary elections held

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- 5 MARCH 2026 → Nepal elections held
- READING → India engaged the successor arrangement in each case, not the outgoing one

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: READING — India engaged the successor arrangement in each case, not the outgoing one.

WATER-SECURITY LEDGER

DECEMBER 2026

THE 1996 GANGA WATERS TREATY EXPIRES

CORE CLAIM

- 23 APRIL 2025 → Cabinet Committee on Security holds the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance
- **CONDITION** → until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures cross-border terrorism support

MECHANISM

- 16 MAY 2026 → India restates that the Court of Arbitration is illegally constituted
- DECEMBER 2026 → the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- 13 FEBRUARY 2026 → India states that renewal talks had not begun
- DOCTRINE TEST → non-reciprocity is least stable where the shared resource is finite

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DOCTRINE TEST → non-reciprocity is least stable where the shared resource is finite.

STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS

EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025

MISSION LEVEL CHANGED; NO RECOGNITION DECLARATION

TERMS OF REFERENCE

NEGOTIATIONS LAUNCHED; NOT A CONCLUDED FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination	EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration	ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement	TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement	UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

CORE CLAIM

- ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
- UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

MECHANISM

- EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration
- TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
- UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS

AN EXECUTIVE DECISION ON OPERATION; EXPRESSLY NOT TREATY TERMINATION

UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025

TO STOP ALL MILITARY ACTIVITIES; NOT A CEASEFIRE AGREEMENT

EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025

MISSION LEVEL CHANGED; NO RECOGNITION DECLARATION

TERMS OF REFERENCE

NEGOTIATIONS LAUNCHED; NOT A CONCLUDED FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination	EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration	ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
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CORE CLAIM

• ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination

• UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

MECHANISM

• EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration

• TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination

• UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement.

STAGE 10

DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND

DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND

TEESTA SHOWS INDIAN STATE-LEVEL INTERESTS CONSTRAINING A BILATERAL AGREEMENT

PARTNER POLITICS

INDIA MUST CLOSELY FOLLOW NEIGHBOURING POLITICAL TRENDS

THE GUJRAL PRINCIPLE SITS IN TENSION WITH THAT NECESSITY

OUTSIDE POWER

SIKRI'S DATED CRITIQUE OF EXTERNAL GUIDANCE OF SOUTH ASIA

CITE THE CONSTRAINT WITH ITS DATE AND ITS AUTHOR

PARTNER POLITICS → India must closely follow neighbouring political trends

FEDERAL → Teesta shows Indian state-level interests constraining a bilateral agreement

NON-INTERFERENCE → the Gujral principle sits in tension with that necessity

OUTSIDE POWER → Sikri's dated critique of external guidance of South Asia policy

CORE CLAIM

• FEDERAL → Teesta shows Indian state-level interests constraining a bilateral agreement

• PARTNER POLITICS → India must closely follow neighbouring political trends

MECHANISM

• NON-INTERFERENCE → the Gujral principle sits in tension with that necessity

• OUTSIDE POWER → Sikri's dated critique of external guidance of South Asia policy

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• RULE → cite the constraint with its date and its author, never as current fact

• FEDERAL → Teesta shows Indian state-level interests constraining a bilateral agreement

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the constraint with its date and its author, never as current fact.

STAGE 11

ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND

ESTABLISH STRUCTURAL ASYMMETRY AND THE NON-RECIPROCAL DOCTRINAL RESPONSE

DISTINGUISH SMALLER-STATE AND LARGER-STATE ENGAGEMENT PATTERNS BY NAME

CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT WITH ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL

APPLY THE IMPLEMENTATION-CREDIBILITY TEST ACROSS A CHANGE OF GOVERNMENT

EVIDENCE LIMIT

USE NAMED INDIA-CENTRIC EVIDENCE SUCH

OPEN → establish structural asymmetry and the non-reciprocal doctrinal response

BUILD → distinguish smaller-state and larger-state engagement patterns by name

TEST → cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level and its limitation

CLOSE → apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government

EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Use named India-centric evidence such

CORE CLAIM

• OPEN → establish structural asymmetry and the non-reciprocal doctrinal response

• BUILD → distinguish smaller-state and larger-state engagement patterns by name

MECHANISM

• TEST → cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level and its limitation

• CLOSE → apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Use named India-centric evidence such...

• OPEN → establish structural asymmetry and the non-reciprocal doctrinal response

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Use named India-centric evidence such.

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

BILATERAL SUMMIT-LEVEL MECHANISMS (ANNUAL OR PERIODIC LEADER-LEVEL)

MEA BILATERAL BRIEFS (INDIA-SRI LANKA AND INDIA-BHUTAN, CURRENT TO

POWER-GRID AND TRANSIT PROTOCOLS ARE TYPICALLY NEGOTIATED AND RENEWED

REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK OVERLAY (SAARC, BIMSTEC) PROVIDES THE MULTILATERAL

BOUNDARY CASE — HISTORICAL INTERVENTION VS. STATED NON-INTERFERENCE

BOUNDARY CASE — SMALLER-STATE HEDGING

EVEN NEIGHBOURS THAT VALUE

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

• CAUTION: Bilateral summit-level mechanisms (annual or periodic leader-level

• MEA bilateral briefs (India-Sri Lanka and India-Bhutan, current to July

• CAUTION: Power-grid and transit protocols are typically negotiated and renewed

• CAUTION: Regional-framework overlay (SAARC, BIMSTEC) provides the multilateral

ADVANCED DEBATE

• CAUTION: Boundary case — historical intervention vs. stated non-interference:

• CAUTION: Boundary case — smaller-state hedging: even neighbours that value

• CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan as a near-neighbour: Tharoor's inclusion of

• CAUTION: Regime change discontinuity risk: any government transition in a

LEGACY / NUANCE

• CAUTION: Boundary case — the implementation-credibility test with dated

• CAUTION: Non-reciprocity has fiscal and political cost: the Gujral Doctrine's

• CAUTION: Regional-framework preference vs. bilateral delivery tension: smaller

• CAUTION: Domestic political engagement vs. non-interference principle: the need

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.